ONLINE COMMUNICATION: FORMAL EMAILS

The structure of a formal email

Introduction

Greeting:

- Dear Mr/Mrs/Ms (surname of the recipient, e.g. Mr Black)
- Dear Sir/Madam (if you don't know the name of the recipient) or more generally 'To whom it may concern'

Introductory sentence (indicates clearly the reason for writing: consistent with the subject of the email). Introduce yourself briefly, then follow on with:

- I am writing with regard to… (email subject)
- I am writing in connection with… (email subject)
- I am writing in reference to…
- I am writing to enquire about…

If you are writing an email to send information, you can start with one of the following sentences:

- I am writing to let you know…
- I am delighted / pleased to tell you… (if you're communicating good news)
- I regret to inform you that… (if you're communicating bad news)
- We would like to apologise for… / Please accept our apologies for…

If instead you are replying to an email you received, you can say:

- I am writing in response to…
- I am writing in reply to…
- I am writing to thank you for… (if you need to thank the recipient)

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- Thank you for your letter regarding…

Body of the text

The text should be divided into short paragraphs that avoid abbreviations and acronyms.

Various ways to write a final invitation before ending the email:

- I look forward to hearing from you soon
- Thank you in advance
- For further information, please do not hesitate to contact me
- Please let me know if you have any questions

Conclusion

The most common ways to end an email:

- Best regards
- (Kind) regards
- Yours faithfully (if you began the email with ‘Dear Sir/Madam’ because you don’t know the name of the recipient)
- Yours sincerely (if you began the email with ‘Dear Mr/Mrs/Ms + surname

Signature

Important information about you:

- name and surname
- job title
- relative details about your company (name, address…)
- link to the company website

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WRITING A FORMAL EMAIL

Complete the email, then write a reply.

_____ (1) Mr Taylor,

I am _____ (2) in _____ (3) to your email of 15 May _____ (4) the delivery of the Maxwell dining table you ordered.

In April there was a fire at the factory and it had to close down for a week. We _____ (5) to inform you that there are _____ (6) of up to four weeks on most orders.

We promise to do everything we can to speed up deliveries, but in the meantime we would like to _____ (7) for the obvious inconvenience this has caused.

Yours _____ (8),

Peter Johnsson

Customer services manager

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KEY

1) Dear
2) writing
3) response / reply
4) regarding / about
5) regret
6) delays
7) apologise
8) sincerely

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FORMAL EXPRESSIONS

Match the headings with the groups of expressions. In each group there is one formal expression. Which is it?

Requesting information	Advising	Expressing enthusiasm	Changing the subject	Apologising	Expressing surprise

1. ……
   Sorry about forgetting to tell you.
   Please forgive me for making that mistake.
   I would like to apologise for arriving so late.
   It was silly of me to suggest that.

2. ……..
   Can you give me an idea when it'll finish?
   I would be grateful if you could tell me the cost.
   I'd like to know if you've got a spare ticket.
   Could you let me know what time you'll be here?

3. ……
   My advice to you is to consider it most carefully.
   It'd be a good idea to try again.
   I really think you should go somewhere else.
   If I were you, I'd tell her now.

4. ……
   That reminds me, it's her birthday next week.
   By the way, what's his name?
   With reference to the accommodation, there are certain changes…
   Anyway, how's life in general?

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5. ……
   Believe it or not, I've just won the lottery!
   Funnily enough, we were both at the same primary school.
   I was most surprised to discover that the price has risen.
   You'll never believe this, but she's his cousin!

6. ……..
   It's a really exciting place to go with friends!
   I think it's great that everyone will be there!
   I'm delighted to hear you won a prize!
   I am extremely enthusiastic about learning Chinese.

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KEY

1. Apologising (I would like to apologise for…)
2. Requesting information (I would be grateful if you could…)
3. Advising (My advice to you is to…)
4. Changing the subject (With reference to…)
5. Expressing surprise (I was most surprised to discover that…)
6. Expressing enthusiasm (I am extremely enthusiastic about…)

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COMMUNICATION OVERLOAD

Read the text below and answer the questions.

Communication overload is a common challenge for many employees, especially in the era of remote work and digital tools. It can lead to stress, confusion, lower productivity, and reduced engagement. How can you cope with the constant flow of messages, emails, calls, and notifications? Here are some tips to improve your internal communication skills and create a more balanced and effective communication culture.

1 Define your communication goals

Before you send or request any information, ask yourself: what is the purpose of this communication? What are the expected outcomes and actions? By clarifying your communication goals, you can avoid unnecessary or irrelevant messages, prioritize the most important ones, and use the most suitable channels and formats.

2 Respect your audience's preferences and needs

Not everyone communicates in the same way or has the same availability and preferences. Some people may prefer emails over calls, while others may favour instant messaging or video conferencing. Some people may need more details and explanations, while others may want concise and clear summaries. Some people may have different time zones, schedules, or workloads. Respect your audience's preferences and needs by asking for their feedback, adapting your communication style, and being mindful of their context and constraints.

3 Use the right tools and platforms

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There are many tools and platforms available for communication, such as email, chat, phone, video, intranet, social media, and collaboration software. Each one has its own advantages and disadvantages, depending on the type, frequency, urgency, and complexity of the communication. Use the right tools and platforms for your communication goals, and avoid using too many or switching between them unnecessarily.

4 Filter and organize your information

One of the main causes of communication overload is the lack of filtering and organizing of information. Filter and organize your information by using labels, folders, categories, tags, filters, and search functions. Create a system that helps you sort, prioritize, and access the information you need, and delete or archive the information you don't need.

5 Set boundaries and expectations

Another cause of communication overload is the lack of boundaries and expectations. When you feel that you have to respond to every message or request immediately, or that you have to be available at all times, you can experience stress, burnout, and reduced work-life balance. Set boundaries and expectations by establishing clear and realistic deadlines, response times, and communication hours. Turn off or mute your notifications when you need to focus, take breaks, or enjoy your personal time.

6 Communicate with empathy and respect

Finally, the most important internal communication skill is to communicate with empathy and respect. Communication overload can affect your emotions, moods, and attitudes, and lead to misunderstandings, conflicts, or resentment. Communicate with empathy and respect by listening actively, acknowledging

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feelings, expressing appreciation, giving constructive feedback, apologizing when needed, and resolving issues constructively. By communicating with empathy and respect, you can build trust, rapport, and engagement, and foster a positive and supportive communication culture.

Adopted from:

https://www.linkedin.com/advice/0/how-can-you-help-employees-deal-communication#:~:text=Communication%20overload%20is%20a%20common,lower%20productivity%2C%20and%20reduced%20engagement.

Task

How do you cope with the constant flow of messages, emails, calls, and notifications? Do they affect your emotions and moods?

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